

SOUTHSIDE PUSHBACK
Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin leading a DMK rally in Chennai, Feb. 3

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IT'S FROM THE SOUTH THAT THE I.N.D.I.A. PARTNERS HOPE TO LIMIT THE BJP, WITH A STRONG SHOWING IN TN AND KERALA, AND GAINS IN KARNTAKA, ANDHRA, TELANGANA

20 seats is evident from the fact that three of its most high-profile leaders—Rahul Gandhi, K.C. Venugopal and Shashi Tharoor—are in the fray from here. While the BJP is a marginal player in the state, which has historically seen a duel between the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) and the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF), the eventual outcome is unlikely to affect the Opposition forces. Whoever the winner, the UDF or the LDF, the numbers will accrue to I.N.D.I.A.'s tally.

In Karnataka, history has been on the saffron party's side despite the Congress pulling off a major upset in the assembly polls last year. Modi's popularity, too, continues to work in the BJP's favour when it comes to Lok Sabha elections. It is no surprise, therefore, that the BJP has cornered a majority of the state's 28 seats in the past four elections, accompanied by a steady rise in vote share, which crossed the 50 per cent mark. In 2019, the BJP won 26 out of the 28 seats.

The party is not taking any chances this time either, tying up with H.D. Deve Gowda's Janata Dal (Secular)—which had tied up with the Congress in 2019—to secure the Vokkaliga vote and anointing B.S. Yediyurappa's son B.Y. Vijayendra as president of the state BJP to assuage the Lingayats upset with Yediyurappa's removal in 2021.

To counter the BJP's moves, the Congress is relying heavily on Chief Minister Siddaramaiah, an exponent of AHINDA politics—a Kannada acronym for the social coalition of the 'Alpasankhyataru' (minorities), Hindulidavaru (backward classes) and Dalitaru (Dalits)—and Deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga strongman. Siddaramaiah had stirred trouble for the party by accepting a caste enumeration report which, according to leaked information, suggests that AHINDAs constitute 60 per cent of the state's population, with Muslims outnumbering the Vokkaligas and the Lingayats, much to the chagrin of these two dominant communities. The Karnataka Congress is also going into this election on the back of the implementation of its five poll guarantees such as the free bus ride for women and free supply of 200 units of electricity, a plank that may help it gain more seats from the BJP this time. "This time, a majority of the AHINDA, women and the Vokkaligas are more likely to back the Congress because of the five guarantees and the dual leadership of Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar. However, most of Lingayat votes will stay with the BJP," says Professor S.Y. Surendra Kumar, chairperson of the political science department at Bangalore University.